

Figure 22: V.O. Chidambaram Pillai and his wife Meenakshi. Photograph embossed on white marble and studded with pearls. (Gifted to VOC by an Italian merchant).

In December 1911, on VOC's instructions, his wife Meenakshi had moved to Cannanore with her two young sons and her elder brother, G. Pitchaiah Pillai. They resided in a rented house not far from the central jail. The objective was to pursue VOC's early release through appeals and petitions. Little would she have known then of the further difficulties that the dying SSNCo would cause to her family. At barely twenty-two, Meenakshi (Figure 22) showed extraordinary courage in the most dispiriting circumstances. She tried to meet her husband as many times as the prison manuals and the whimsical officials would permit. Religiously carrying out VOC's instructions regarding memorializing the government, arranging for the publication of his books, and occasionally aiding in surreptitious communication, Meenakshi raised money for the judicial appeals, coordinated with members of the family to sell off property, negotiated loans, pledged her jewels, etc.—all these even as she was shadowed by the police. (Such was the fear that a local typist, intimidated by the police, declined to type out her official correspondence.) Meenakshi kept copies of the correspondence during the year she spent in Cannanore; luckily these have survived, though sadly the addressees of many of the letters are not known. The language and style of the letters belie the fact